Why Rudolf Steiner Discourages Competition in Sport and Movement During the Early Years

A categorised overview of the anthroposophical and Waldorf rationale, with primary-source references

Steiner's objection to early competition does not come from sports science. It flows from his developmental philosophy, set out chiefly in the 1907 essay *The Education of the Child in the Light of Anthroposophy* (GA 34) and elaborated in later lecture cycles to Waldorf teachers. The categories below organise that reasoning and anchor each to where it appears in Steiner's work.

The Categories

1. The seven-year developmental stages

Steiner's framework rests on the idea that each phase of childhood unfolds a different aspect of the human being, and that education must match the phase. Before the change of teeth the child is given a physical pattern to copy; only between the change of teeth and puberty should the surrounding world bring things of inner meaning and value. Competition draws on the comparing, judging faculties of a much later stage, so introducing it early works against the developmental grain.

Source: The Education of the Child in the Light of Anthroposophy (GA 34).

2. Imitation and example, not self-assertion

Steiner's “two magic words” for early childhood are imitation and example. He held that for no age is imitation more true than the first stage of childhood, before the change of teeth, when essentially all of the child's activity is imitation of what is seen around them. Competition fosters rivalry and self-assertion, the opposite of this absorptive, imitative way of being.

Source: GA 34; Waldorf early-childhood literature on learning through imitation.

3. The child as a “sense organ”

Steiner described the young child as almost wholly a sense organ: a striking event nearby, such as an outburst of anger, passes right through the child and affects even circulation and digestion, because young children lack the buffers and filters adults use to screen out impressions. On this view the emotional charge of winning and losing is not merely psychological — it reaches into the child's bodily development.

Source: Soul Economy (GA 303) and related early-childhood writings.

4. Protecting the formation of the physical body

A central and consequential claim: the forms developed in the first seven years set the template for all later growth. Steiner argued that true forms beget true forms and misshapen forms beget misshapen ones, and that educators can never repair what they neglect in these first years. Forcing performance and strain too early is therefore seen as risking lasting physical harm.

Source: GA 34.

5. Delaying premature judgment

Steiner held that the faculties of independent, critical judgment should not be awakened too soon. The middle-childhood years work on the feeling life through a pictorial, imaginative approach, because the powers of mental imagery mature only gradually and must be prepared well before their proper time. The self-conscious comparison that competition demands belongs to a later phase; awakening it early was thought to damage the child's later capacity for independent thought.

Source: The Child's Changing Consciousness and Waldorf Education (GA 306); GA 34.

6. The “I” incarnates only at adolescence

The metaphysical core of the position: Steiner taught that the subjective self — the ego and astral body — binds fully to the body only at sexual maturity. The transition at around fourteen or fifteen (earlier for girls) differs in kind from the one at seven, as the adolescent now relates this subjective life to the objective physical and etheric spheres. Competition stimulates ego-consciousness and a sense of separateness before this is developmentally appropriate.

Source: Education for Adolescents (GA 302).

7. Reverence and authority over rivalry (ages 7–14)

Even after early childhood, Steiner placed feeling, rhythm, and a respect for authority — not contest — at the centre of education. The sense for authority between the change of teeth and puberty was treated as an inborn need that must be respected, because experiencing reverence then is what later allows the appropriate use of freedom. Rivalry cuts against this.

Source: The Education of the Child (GA 34); Soul Economy (GA 303).

8. The practical sports application

Waldorf schools translate this into a graded approach to athletics. In the first seven years, free play and simple non-competitive games that bring the joy of movement are considered all that is needed for healthy development. Only after the ages of nine and ten, as the child becomes less dreamy and more self-aware, do athletics advance toward genuine skill practice, with formal competitive sport reserved for around the age of twelve and adolescence.

Source: A Waldorf Approach to Athletics, Camellia Waldorf School.

A Note on These Sources

These categories rest on Steiner's spiritual framework — the etheric and astral bodies, the incarnating "I" — which is anthroposophical doctrine rather than scientific consensus. Some of its practical conclusions (delaying competitive pressure, prioritising free play) nonetheless overlap with mainstream youth-sport research on early specialisation, dropout, and intrinsic motivation. The strongest primary anchor for the whole position is *The Education of the Child in the Light of Anthroposophy* (GA 34); the adolescence and ego material is in *Education for Adolescents* (GA 302). Both are freely readable on the Rudolf Steiner Archive.

References

1. **Steiner, R.** (1907). The Education of the Child in the Light of Anthroposophy (GA 34). Rudolf Steiner Archive. https://rsarchive.org/Articles/GA034/English/Singles/EduChi_essay.html
2. **Steiner, R.** (1921). Education for Adolescents, eight lectures, Stuttgart, 12–19 June 1921 (GA 302). Rudolf Steiner Archive. https://rsarchive.org/Lectures/GA302/English/AP1996/19210616d01.html
3. **Steiner, R.** (1923). The Child's Changing Consciousness and Waldorf Education, Lecture IV (GA 306). Rudolf Steiner Archive. https://rsarchive.org/Lectures/GA306/English/RSP1988/19230418p01.html
4. **Steiner, R.** (1921–1922). Soul Economy: Body, Soul and Spirit in Waldorf Education (GA 303), incl. "Children Before the Seventh Year." Anthroposophic Press.
5. **IASWECE.** Essential Characteristics of Steiner/Waldorf Education for the Child from Birth to Seven. International Association for Steiner/Waldorf Early Childhood Education. https://iaswece.org/waldorf-education/what-is-waldorf-education/
6. **Camellia Waldorf School.** (2023). Building Skills Through Athletics: A Waldorf Approach to Athletics. https://www.camelliawaldorf.org/post/building-skills-through-athletics
7. **Oldfield, L.** (2012). Free to Learn: Introducing Steiner Waldorf Early Childhood Education. Hawthorn Press.

Citations of Steiner's works follow the standard "GA" (Gesamtausgabe) numbering of his collected works. Archive links point to the public English translations on rsarchive.org.